CRITIQUE PAPER

English for Academic and Professional Purposes

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Objectives

At the end of the discussion, the students are expected to:

Evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of a creative work or academic article based on specific criteria;

Demonstrate an open-minded attitude when reviewing perspectives that differ from their own; and

Construct a well-organized critique paper following a standard format.

What is a Critique Paper?

A critique is an evaluative analysis that carefully examines another writer's work through either a focused lens—such as specific literary techniques—or a holistic assessment. Whether evaluating professional literature, academic research via peer review, or modern consumer products through user reviews, the goal remains to provide a balanced, in-depth critique that highlights both strengths and weaknesses.

Writing a critique on a work helps you to develop:

1. Knowledge of the work's subject area or related works,
2. An understanding of the work's purpose, intended audience, development of argument, structure of evidence or creative style, and
3. A recognition of the strengths and weaknesses of the work.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Comprehensive.
A good review analyzes all the elements of the genre to which the particular work belongs.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Critical.

The review is in-depth. Critical approaches to writing a review are employed by the author.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Timely.

The review is about a work that is relatively recent.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Objective.
The review is not tainted by the author's personal biases and prejudices.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Credible.

The review is acceptable to many, if not all. The reviewer made use of generally accepted criteria in evaluating the subject work.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Original.

The critique is simply not piecing together other critic's reviews. The author provides his/her own inputs that may be the same or different from that of other critiques.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Fair.

The author does not unfairly compare the work with another work.

Characteristics of a Good Critique

Decisive.

It decides whether the work is good or bad, of quality or poor quality.

How can you be a good critic?

Knowledgeable of the genre and the topic of the text.

How can you be a good critic?

Proficient in determining the strengths and weaknesses of the text.

How can you be a good critic?

Truthful and not easily influenced by others' opinions.

Reaction Paper vs. Critique Paper

Feature	Reaction Paper	Critique Paper
Primary Focus	Personal feelings and experiences	Academic merit and technical quality
Tone	Subjective, informal, and emotional	Objective, formal, and analytical
Evidence	Personal anecdotes and “I” statements	Evidence from texts and external logic, third POV

Reaction Paper vs. Critique Paper

Feature	Reaction Paper	Critique Paper
Goal	To process how you felt about the work	Academic merit and technical quality
Key Question	How did I feel about this, and why?	Objective, formal, and analytical
Example	Writing about how a documentary on climate change made you feel guilty about your plastic use.	Analyzing that same climate documentary by pointing out biased interviewing techniques or a lack of peer-reviewed data.

Critical Approaches

Various critical approaches govern the writing of a critique paper. Just as a theoretical framework is essential to research, a critical approach is fundamental to a critique. It provides the basis that grounds the critique, giving it a solid foundation. Ultimately, it answers the question: What principles did the writer use?

Formalist Approach

Formalism asserts that the meaning of a work is found entirely within the text itself, treating it as a distinct, self-contained piece of art. This approach rejects external factors—such as the author's life or historical context—focusing instead on intrinsic elements like structure, style, and content.

Formalist Approach

The following are the common aspects looked into formalism:

a. Author's techniques in resolving contradictions within the work
b. Central passage that sums up the entirety of the work
c. Contribution of parts and the work as a whole to its aesthetic quality
d. Relationship of the form and the content.
e. Use of imagery to develop the symbols in the work
f. Interconnectedness of various parts of the work
g. Unity in the works

Formalist Approach

The Road Not Taken

Two roads diverged in a yellow wood,
And sorry I could not travel both
And be one traveler, long I stood
And looked down one as far as I could
To where it bent in the undergrowth;

Then took the other, as just as fair,
And having perhaps the better claim,
Because it was grassy and wanted wear;
Though as for that the passing there
Had worn them really about the same,

And both that morning equally lay
In leaves no step had trodden black.
Oh, I kept the first for another day!
Yet knowing how way leads on to way,
I doubted if I should ever come back.

I shall be telling this with a sigh
Somewhere ages and ages hence:
Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—
I took the one less traveled by,
And that has made all the difference.

— ROBERT FROST —

Fire and Ice

by Robert Frost

Some say the world will end in fire,
Some say in ice.
From what I've tasted of desire
I hold with those who favor fire.
But if it had to perish twice,
I think I know enough of hate
To say that for destruction ice
Is also great
And would suffice.

Formalist Approach

Prior to drafting, review your notes to determine the most effective analytical framework. You should answer the following questions in complete sentences to guide your thoughts:

- Which specific literary element resonated with me most?
- How do the different components and literary devices of the book connect?
- What central theme or message did the author intend to convey?

Finally, construct a thesis statement that explicitly defines your primary argument regarding the novel.

Feminist Approach

Feminist criticism examines literature and events through the lens of gender dynamics, focusing on the portrayal of women as subjects of sociopolitical, psychological, and economic oppression. This approach challenges patriarchal norms—the cultural assumption of male superiority—and explores how meaning is constructed differently based on sex-ascribed roles. When applying this lens, the reviewer evaluates the work or event from their own sexual identity, highlighting imbalances of power or representation.

Feminist Approach

The following are the common aspects looked into feminism:

a. Shows that culture determines gender
b. Shows gender equality (or lack of it) is presented in text
c. Shows gender issues are presented in literary works and other aspects of human production and daily life
d. Shows women are socially, politically, psychologically, and economically oppressed by patriarchy
e. Show patriarchal ideology is an overpowering presence.

Feminist Approach

Feminist Approach

The First Wave: Emerging in the early 1900s, this era was defined by the suffragette movement, where the primary goal was securing women's right to vote to achieve political equality.

The Second Wave: Spanning from the early 1960s through the late 1980s, this period targeted systemic legal barriers, specifically focusing on reproductive freedom and equality in the professional workplace.

Feminist Approach

The Third Wave: Beginning in the early 1990s and lasting into the 2010s, this phase broadened the movement's scope by introducing intersectionality—the study of how different social identities overlap—as a core principle.

The Fourth Wave: Starting around 2010, this current phase maintains the goals of previous waves while placing a significant emphasis on combating sexual violence and harassment against women.

Reader-response Approach

Reader-response criticism asserts that a text remains incomplete until it is engaged by an audience. Rather than being passive observers, readers are active participants who bring their unique backgrounds and perspectives to the material, essentially "creating" the meaning through their interaction with the work. Under this framework, a text does not possess a single, fixed message; instead, it exists as a dynamic process of mutual influence between the author's words and the reader's personal interpretation. The common aspects looked into when using reader response criticism are as follows:

Reader-response Approach

The following are the common aspects looked into reader-response:

a. Interaction between the reader and the text in creating meaning, and

b. The impact of the reader's delivery of sounds and visuals on enhancing and changing meaning.

Reader-response Approach

APO ON THE WALL
-BJ PATINO

There's this man's photo on the wall
Of my father's office at home, you
Know, where father brings his work,
Where he doesn't look strange
Still wearing his green uniform
And colored breast plates, where,
To prove that he works hard, he
Also brought a photo of his boss
Whom he calls Apo, so Apo could
You know, hang around on the wall
Behind him and look over his shoulders
To make sure he's snappy and all.
Father snapped at me once, caught me
Sneaking around his office at home
Looking at the stuff on his wall- handguns,
Plaques, a sword, medals a rifle-
Told me that was no place for a boy
Only men, when he didn't really
Have to tell me because, you know,
That photo of Apo on the wall was already
Looking at me around,
His eyes following me like he was
That scary Jesus in the hallway, saying
I know what you're doing.

Biographical Approach

This approach is premised on the fact that the author's life has a significant bearing on how the work is written and how it will take shape. Circumstances including the author's education, background, and way of life are reflected in the writing. This approach is based on the premise that in the act of writing, the author is not just writing about the work but bringing into the work an entire belief system and a whole set of circumstances, both past and present.

Biographical Approach

The following are the common aspects looked into biographical approach:

a. Autobiographical elements such as real-life experiences, people, or places in the story.

b. The author's emotional state, desires, unfulfilled wishes, or psychological conflicts that manifest in the text's characters and plot.

c. The author's political, religious, or philosophical stances, and whether they are portrayed directly or through the characters

d. Influence of parents, siblings, spouses or significant others on the relationships depicted in the literary work.

Biographical Approach

Marxist Criticism Approach

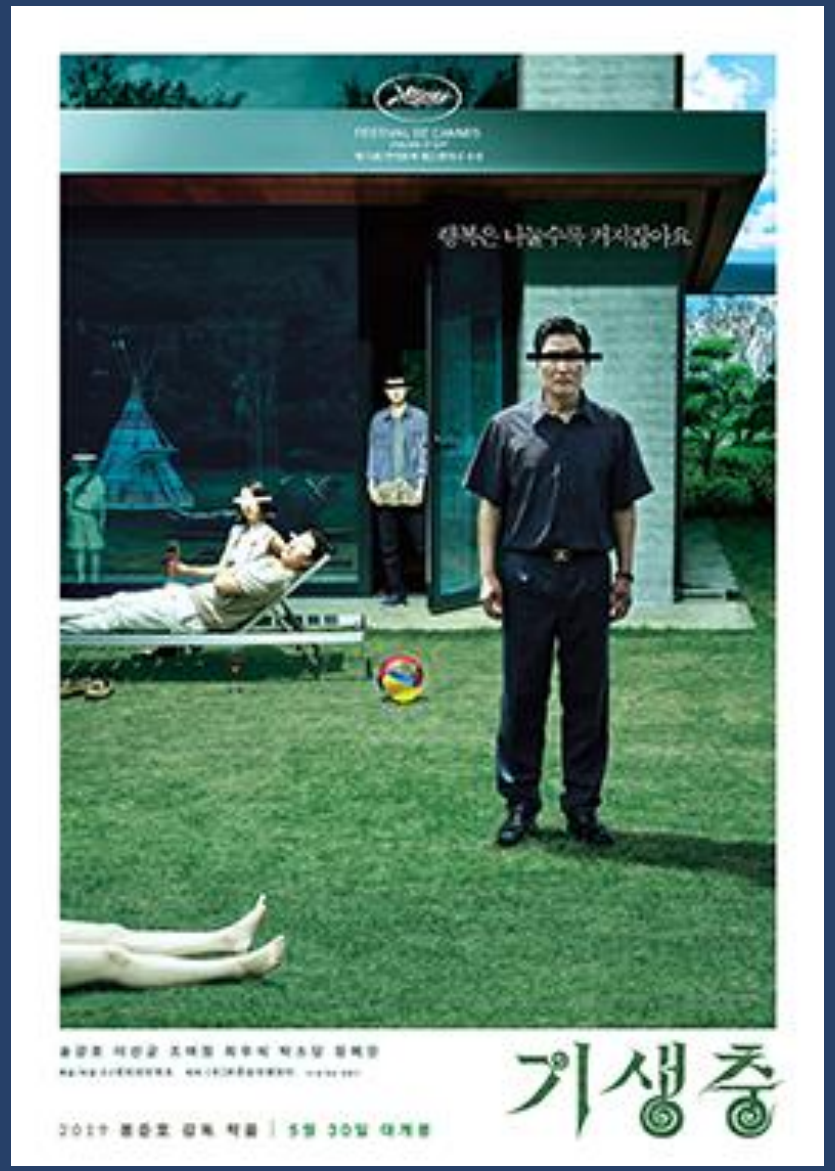
This approach is concerned with differences between economic classes and implications of a capitalist system, such as the continuing conflicts between the working class and the elite. Hence, it attempts to reveal that the ultimate source of people's experience is the socioeconomic system.

Marxist Criticism Approach

The following are the common aspects looked into Marxist criticism approach:

a. Social class as represented in the work
b. Social class of the writer/creator
c. Social class of the characters
d. Conflicts and interactions between economic classes

Marxist Criticism Approach



Historical Approach

This approach recognizes that the social and cultural environments have a tremendous effect on events and situations. When you use this approach, you should consider the time, social milieu, political climate, and socio-political context in relation to the event or phenomenon that you are writing about. This approach requires that you consider the work in relation to the period during which it was written. Further, this approach argues that the work is influenced by everything around it, including the way the event or phenomenon is perceived by people in society.

Historical Approach

The following are the common aspects looked into historical approach:

- Chronology: Placing events in order to understand cause-and-effect
- Change over Time: Identifying how societal norms, laws, and cultural attitudes shift, and investigating the specific catalysts (like war, technology, or social movements) that caused those changes.
- Contextualization: Connecting a specific text or event to the broader "big picture" of the era to see how it was influenced by the environment surrounding it.
- Contingency: Recognizing that historical outcomes were not inevitable; they were shaped by specific human choices and chance occurrences.

Historical Approach

Techniques in Offering Praise or Suggesting Improvements and Solutions

1. Use of Qualifying adjectives and adverbs Identifies just how many or how much is affected by a certain view.

Example: Some users find the new interface difficult to navigate compared with the first.

Techniques in Offering Praise or Suggesting Improvements and Solutions

2. Use of modal verbs
Attaches appropriate extent of certainty to a claim.

Example: Some users may find the new interface difficult to navigate compared with the first.

Techniques in Offering Praise or Suggesting Improvements and Solutions

3. Use of tentative verbs
The use of modal verbs, also assigns extent of certainty to a claim

Example: It appears that users find the new interface difficult to navigate compared with the first.

Techniques in Offering Praise or Suggesting Improvements and Solutions

4. Offering an ideal state
These are statements that express what could have made the work better or what could possibly make the work better.

Example: What the researcher could have done was to summarize the data in a line graph, not a pie chart, since it dealt with trends in printer sales over a 30-year period.

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Steps in Writing a Critique Paper

1. Decide what to look at

The first thing that you need to do before you start your review is decide what aspects of the item you are going to evaluate. This means asking the question "What is it that can be good or bad about something I'm going to review?"

Example: When watching a movie, one can look at the acting, the writing, or the cinematography.

Steps in Writing a Critique Paper

2. Decide what makes things good or bad.
Before you can decide whether something is good or bad, you have to figure out what you mean by good and bad. Based on your preferences, apply the standards you’ve set to the material you are reviewing.

Example: You think a movie is good because it is a comedy, which is a genre that you like.

Steps in Writing a Critique Paper

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It is now time to start putting your essay together

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